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Delilah

The woman of Sorek who sold Samson's secret for Philistine silver.

Delilah lived in the valley of Sorek, and Samson loved her. She is the only woman in Samson's story whom Judges names. The lords of the Philistines each offered her eleven hundred pieces of silver to find out the secret of his great strength. Three times Samson lied to her, and three times she tested his answer while men waited in hiding. Then she pressed him day after day until he told her all his heart. While he slept on her knees, she had his hair shaved, and the Philistines took him. Scripture does not tell us her nation, her feelings for him, or what became of her. Her story is a sober lesson about betrayal and about playing with temptation.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hebrew <i>Delilah</i> . Its meaning is uncertain
<i>Home</i>	The valley of Sorek (Judges 16:4)
<i>Nation</i>	Not stated; many assume a Philistine
<i>When</i>	Late in Samson's life; no firm date
<i>Key people</i>	Samson; the lords of the Philistines
<i>Price</i>	Eleven hundred pieces of silver from each lord (Judges 16:5)
<i>Main passages</i>	Judges 16:4-21
<i>New Testament</i>	Not named

*"And she said unto him, How canst thou say, I love thee, when
thine heart is not with me? thou hast mocked me these three
times, and hast not told me wherein thy great strength lieth."*

Judges 16:15, KJV

The life of Delilah

Judges gives no dates or ages for Delilah. The events below follow Judges 16 in order, and they may have taken place over days or weeks.

Late in Samson's life	● Loved by Samson After Samson escapes from Gaza, he loves a woman in the valley of Sorek whose name is Delilah. Judges says plainly that he loved her, but it never says that she loved him. <i>Judges 16:1-4</i>
The offer	● Bribed by the lords The lords of the Philistines come up to her. They ask her to entice him and learn where his great strength lies and how they may bind him. Each lord promises her eleven hundred pieces of silver. <i>Judges 16:5</i>
Three attempts	● Three lies Samson tells her to bind him with seven green withs, then with new ropes, then to weave his seven locks into the web. Each time she cries, "The Philistines be upon thee, Samson," and he breaks free. <i>Judges 16:6-14</i>
Day after day	● Presses him She accuses him of mocking her and asks how he can say he loves her. She presses him daily until "his soul was vexed unto death," and he tells her the truth about the razor. <i>Judges 16:15-17</i>
The last night	● Betrays him She sends for the lords, who come with the money. She makes him sleep on her knees and calls a man to shave his seven locks. The LORD has departed from Samson, and he is taken. <i>Judges 16:18-21</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Judges does not say whether Delilah loved Samson, whether she was a Philistine or an Israelite, or what happened to her after his capture. Later writers and artists have filled these gaps, but the text is silent.

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- 1 **Accepted a bribe.** She agreed to the lords' offer to discover Samson's secret for money. *Judges 16:5*
 - 2 **Tested his answers.** Three times she bound him as he described, with men lying in wait in the chamber. *Judges 16:6-14*
 - 3 **Used his love as leverage.** "How canst thou say, I love thee, when thine heart is not with me?" *Judges 16:15*
 - 4 **Wore him down.** She pressed him daily with her words until he gave in. *Judges 16:16-17*
 - 5 **Knew when he told the truth.** She saw that he had told her all his heart and called the lords to come up "this once." *Judges 16:18*
 - 6 **Handed him over.** She had his hair shaved while he slept and began to afflict him, and his strength went from him. *Judges 16:19-21*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Delilah.

Old Testament

Judges 16:4–21	This is the whole account.
Echoes	Samson's first wife was also pressed to get a secret from him for the Philistines (Judges 14:15–17). Proverbs warns of flattering words that lead a young man astray (Proverbs 7:21–23). Joseph refused temptation and fled (Genesis 39:7–12).

New Testament

Echoes	Judas Iscariot agrees to betray Jesus for money: "What will ye give me, and I will deliver him unto you?" (Matthew 26:14–16). "The love of money is the root of all evil" (1 Timothy 6:10).
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For discussion

1. *Observe:* How many times did Delilah try to learn Samson's secret, and what did she say each time (Judges 16:6–20)?
2. *Understand:* Samson saw the traps each time and still stayed. Why do you think he did?
3. *Apply:* Delilah wore Samson down little by little. What pressure in your life is slowly wearing you down?
4. *Apply:* Delilah traded a relationship for money. What would help you put people ahead of gain this week?

Group notes